LIBERTY COUNTY BUILDING DEPARTMENT

Permit Desk Reference

For internal staff use · October 23, 2026 · Replaces five overlapping guides

What this document is

This is the Liberty County Building Department's counter reference. It answers the questions that come up at the front desk: does this work need a permit, who is allowed to pull it, what the permit covers, what we collect before accepting an application, and which review track the project follows. It replaces the Training & Intake Guide, the Permit Coverage & Inspections Reference, the Permit Exemption Quick Reference, the Planning & Zoning Flow Chart, and the Permit Authorization & Eligibility Guide. Those five overlapped, and a figure that changed had to be changed in all of them.

Where the numbers are

This document contains no fees. Every dollar amount lives in the 2026 Building Department Fee Schedule and nowhere else. Where a fee is relevant here, the text says so and you look it up there.

Where the rules are

This document does not restate setbacks, densities, lot sizes, buffers, or any other figure set by the Land Development Code, the Comprehensive Plan, or a statute. It cites the section and you read the figure from the source. A dimension copied into a staff guide is a dimension that can go out of date silently, and one already did.

THE TWO RULES THAT KEEP THIS DOCUMENT CORRECT

No fee appears in this document - the Fee Schedule is the only place a dollar amount lives. No figure from the Land Development Code, the Comprehensive Plan or a statute is copied in - the section is cited and you read the figure from the source.

I. Does the work need a permit?

THE ONE-LINE VERSION

Cosmetic work on a single-family home, under the exemption threshold, no trades involved, not in a flood zone. Everything else needs a permit.

The cosmetic work exemption - all six conditions must be true

If you cannot check every one of these, a permit is required.

1	The property is a single-family home.
2	The work is strictly cosmetic and non-structural.
3	The total declared value is under the HB 803 threshold - the figure is in the Fee Schedule.
4	There is no electrical, plumbing, mechanical, gas, or structural work of any kind.
5	The property is NOT in a designated flood hazard area.

6	The job is not part of a larger project divided up to stay under the threshold.

Work that typically qualifies

Category	Examples
Flooring	Carpet, tile, vinyl, laminate, hardwood - replacing floor covering.
Cabinets & countertops	Swapping cabinets or counters, provided no plumbing or wiring is moved.
Painting	Interior or exterior, with no surface preparation that alters structure.
Drywall finishing	Patching, taping, texture, skim coat - not replacing structural sheathing.
Trim & fixtures	Baseboard, crown, door and window casing, shelving.

Work that always needs a permit, at any value

These are excluded whatever the cost - a fifty dollar job included.

Trade	Examples
Electrical	Adding or moving an outlet, switch, light, panel, or any wiring.
Plumbing	Moving a sink, toilet, or any supply or drain line.
Mechanical / HVAC	Ductwork, air handler, condenser, ventilation.
Gas	Any gas line, appliance connection, or propane work.
Structural	Load-bearing walls, framing, headers, beams, roof structure, foundation.

TWO THINGS THAT VOID THE EXEMPTION OUTRIGHT

A designated flood hazard area voids the exemption outright - it does not apply there at all, whatever the cost or scope. So does project splitting: breaking one job into pieces to stay under the threshold is prohibited, and the whole job is then treated as one project.

The second exemption: temporary hurricane and flood walls

A second, separate exemption covers installation of a temporary residential hurricane or flood wall that meets the specified standards. It has no dollar threshold and is unrelated to the cosmetic-work exemption above.

CONFIRM BEFORE WAIVING

Which standard the wall must meet has not been settled. Do not waive a permit for a hurricane or flood wall on the strength of this page - ask the Building Official first.

At the counter

Exempt work	Have them complete the Written Request for Exemption (HB 803) before work begins. Staff verify flood hazard status - a signed form does not establish it.
Not exempt	Normal permit process. Plan review is included in the permit fee; there is no separate plan review charge.

Unsure	Treat it as requiring a permit and ask the Building Official. Work done without a required permit carries a penalty - see the Fee Schedule.

II. Who may pull the permit, and who may do the work

OWNER-OCCUPIED PROPERTY ONLY

The owner-builder exemption applies to owner-occupied property only. Section 489.103(7), Florida Statutes, limits it to property the owner personally occupies or uses. It does NOT apply to rental property, investment property, or any property offered for lease. If the applicant owns a rental home, a duplex they do not live in, or any property currently leased or intended to be leased, they cannot use the owner-builder exemption - a licensed contractor is required for all permitted work on that property, whatever the permit type.

The three tiers

Owner may pull and do the work	The owner can both apply and perform the work themselves.
Owner or licensed contractor	Either may apply. If the owner applies, the owner-occupied limit above applies, and specific trades may still need a licensed person.
Licensed contractor required	The owner cannot pull this permit or do this work, at any value.

By permit type

Fees are deliberately absent from this table. Look the amount up in the Fee Schedule.

Who may pull the permit, and who may do the work

Permit type	Who may pull it	Who may do the work	Licence and authority	Conditions and notes
NEW CONSTRUCTION				
Residential building	Owner or licensed contractor	Owner-builder (own use and occupancy) or licensed general contractor	GC licence if using a contractor. FS 489.103(7)(a)	Applies to one- and two-family residences for the owner's own use, not for sale or lease. The owner must appear in person, sign the affidavit, and directly supervise all work. Cannot hire unlicensed persons.
Commercial building	Licensed contractor required	Licensed general contractor	CGC licence, DBPR certified. FS 489.103(7); FS 489.113	Owner-builder applies only below the statutory construction-cost limit in FS 489.103(7) AND for the owner's own use and occupancy. All other commercial work requires a licensed general contractor.
Factory-built (modular) commercial	Licensed contractor required	Licensed general contractor	CGC licence. FS 553.80(1)(d); FS 489.113	The building must bear a valid State of Florida (DBPR) insignia. A metal or aluminium kit building with no insignia is not a factory-built building and is charged at the standard commercial rate. Foundation and anchoring plans sealed by a Florida-licensed PE are required.
Plumbing, HVAC, gas & mechanical	Licensed contractor required	Licensed plumbing, HVAC or mechanical contractor	Specialty licence. FS 489.113(3)(a); FS 489.105(3)	A general contractor must subcontract plumbing, HVAC and gas to appropriately licensed specialty contractors. There is no owner-builder exception for gas or mechanical systems at any project size.
Fire suppression / hood / sprinkler	Licensed contractor required	Licensed fire suppression contractor	Fire suppression licence. FS 489.105(3)(g); FS 633	Life-safety system. No owner-builder exception under any circumstances.
Pre-manufactured accessory dwelling unit	Owner or licensed contractor	Licensed mobile home installer for setup; licensed trades for utilities	Mobile home installer licence. FS 320.8249; FAC 15C-2.0073	The owner may submit the application, but the physical setup must be performed by a licensed mobile home installer. Electrical and utility connections require licensed trades separately.
ELECTRICAL				
Residential - new service and upgrades	Owner or licensed contractor	Owner (own single-family or duplex, own use) or licensed electrical contractor	Electrical contractor licence if using a contractor. FS 489.503(1); FS 489.103(7)	FS 489.503(1) grants the owner-builder electrical exemption for a single-family home or duplex for the owner's own use. The property may not be for sale or lease. The owner must personally apply and cannot hire unlicensed subcontractors.
Residential - interior wiring	Owner or licensed contractor	Owner (own single-family or duplex, own use) or licensed electrical contractor	Electrical contractor licence if using a contractor. FS 489.503(1)	The interior wiring rate applies only where the existing service, meter and panel stay unchanged. If any of them is replaced or upsized, this becomes a new service. Whether the existing service is adequate is determined by the contractor's load calculation, not the applicant's preference.
Commercial - new service, upgrades, or interior wiring	Licensed contractor required	Licensed electrical contractor	Electrical contractor licence, DBPR certified. FS 489.503; FS 489.537	Commercial electrical work requires a licensed electrical contractor. The owner-builder exception is limited to projects below the statutory cost limit for the owner's own occupancy.

Permit type	Who may pull it	Who may do the work	Licence and authority	Conditions and notes
Reconnect / release	Owner or licensed contractor	Owner (own single-family or duplex, own use) or licensed electrical contractor	Electrical contractor licence if using a contractor; required for commercial. FS 489.503(1)	Inspection and release to the power company where no other electrical work is done. The owner-builder exemption covers only the owner's own home or duplex; a commercial reconnect follows commercial rules.
Outlets and switches	Owner or licensed contractor	Owner (own single-family or duplex, own use) or licensed electrician	Licence if using a contractor. FS 489.503(1)	Same owner-builder electrical exemption. The property may not be offered for sale or lease, and the owner cannot hire unlicensed persons.
Solar - panels and wiring	Owner or licensed contractor may apply	Licensed electrical contractor REQUIRED for all wiring	Electrical contractor licence for wiring. FS 489.103(7)(a)(3)	The statute is explicit: even under an owner-builder permit, a licensed electrical contractor must perform all wiring of solar panels and any interconnection to the home's electrical system. No exceptions.
RENOVATIONS				
Plumbing, gas, mechanical - residential or commercial	Licensed contractor required	Licensed plumbing, HVAC or gas contractor	Specialty licence. FS 489.113(3)(a)	Gas and mechanical systems must be performed by an appropriately licensed specialty contractor. There is no owner-builder exception for gas, residential or not.
Windows & siding	Owner or licensed contractor	Owner (own home, own use) or licensed contractor	Building or residential licence if using a contractor. FS 489.103(7)	Owner-builder applies to owner-occupied property. Any contractor hired must hold a valid building or residential contractor licence.
MOBILE HOMES				
Mobile home set-up	Owner or licensed contractor may apply	Licensed mobile home installer REQUIRED for the physical setup	Mobile home installer licence. FS 320.8249; FAC 15C-2.0073; FS 489.103(7)	The owner may pull the permit but cannot perform the installation. FAC 15C-2.0073 states no person may perform mobile home setup unless licensed under FS 320.8249, which supersedes the general owner-builder exemption in Chapter 489. Electrical connections require a separately licensed electrician.
Mobile home park - development plan review	Owner or authorised agent	Administrative review - no construction	PE or architect seal may be required for plans. LDC 4.6-1; FS 163	Plan review for developing a new park. The fee is set by the Land Development Code, not by the Fee Schedule. Park plans may need a Florida-licensed PE seal. Each home placed in the park still needs its own set-up permit.
ROOFING				
Roofing permit	Owner or licensed contractor	Owner (own one- or two-family residence, own use) or licensed roofing contractor	Roofing contractor licence if using a contractor. FS 489.103(7); FS 489.113(3)(g)	General contractors certified after 1973 may NOT pull a standalone roofing permit or self-perform roofing unless they also hold a roofing contractor licence. If the owner sells or leases within one year of completion, the law presumes the work was done for sale or lease, which violates the exemption.

Permit type	Who may pull it	Who may do the work	Licence and authority	Conditions and notes
ACCESSORY BUILDINGS (NON-RESIDENTIAL)				
Accessory building - open, enclosed, or enclosing an existing open structure	Owner may pull and do the work	Owner or licensed contractor	Licence if using a contractor. FS 489.103(7)(a)(1)	FS 489.103(7)(a)(1) exempts farm outbuildings. Any electrical or plumbing inside still requires licensed subcontractors. Enclosing applies at the modification rate only if the open structure was previously permitted; enclosing changes the wind-design classification, so plan review and inspection are required.
Portable sheds and garages	Owner may pull and do the work	Owner	No licence required at the smaller size. FS 489.103(7); local LDR	Small accessory structures on the owner's property generally do not require a licensed contractor, but must still meet setback, zoning and wind-load requirements. Larger structures may require engineered drawings.
COMPREHENSIVE PLAN REVIEW & ZONING				
Site plan approval - Tier 1	Owner or authorised agent	Administrative review	No licence required to apply. Local LDR; FS 163	Single-family homes, mobile home setups and simple additions. No contractor licence is needed for the application itself.
Site plan approval - Tier 2	Owner or authorised agent	Administrative review	PE or architect seal may be required. Local LDR; FS 163; FS 471; FS 481	Industrial, commercial and multifamily. Complex projects may require site plans sealed by a Florida-licensed professional engineer or registered architect.
Comprehensive plan amendment - small-scale or large-scale	Owner, attorney or agent	County Commission review	FS 163.3187 (small-scale); FS 163.3184 (large-scale)	The acreage that divides small-scale from large-scale is set by FS 163.3187(1)(a) - read it from the statute, and check whether Liberty County qualifies for the higher limit under FS 163.3187(3). State agency review is required for large-scale amendments.
Amendment to land development regulations	Owner or agent	County review	FS 163.3202	A legislative or regulatory change request. Open to any applicant.
Subdivision plat approval	Owner or authorised agent	Requires a licensed surveyor and mapper	Florida PSM must seal the plat. FS 177.011; FS 472	The plat must be prepared and sealed by a Florida professional surveyor and mapper. The owner or agent submits the application; the surveyor performs the technical work. The fee is set by the Land Development Code.
Property split review	Owner or agent	Administrative review	No licence required. Local LDR	Comprehensive plan review prior to a property split. Administrative staff review only.
Special exception, variance, or other conditional use	Owner or authorised agent	Board of Adjustment or County Commission review	No licence required to apply. Local LDR; FS 163	A variance is dimensional relief and is granted only where a hardship unique to the land makes literal compliance impossible. Contact planning for requirements specific to the conditional use category.

Permit type	Who may pull it	Who may do the work	Licence and authority	Conditions and notes
MISCELLANEOUS				
Decks, ramps, porches, covered patios, attached carports	Owner or licensed contractor	Owner (owner-occupied property) or licensed contractor	Licence if using a contractor. FS 489.103(7); local LDR	Any electrical - outdoor lighting, fans, outlets - requires a separate electrical permit. A roofed porch ties into the dwelling and is permitted as part of the house, not as an accessory building. A covered porch counts toward the required yard setbacks; an uncovered deck does not, so adding a roof over an existing deck needs a setback check first.
Sign permit	Owner or licensed contractor	Owner for non-electrical signs; licensed electrical contractor for illuminated signs	Electrical contractor licence if the sign has electrical components. FS 489.105; local LDR	Non-electrical signs may be installed by the owner on their own property. All wiring on an electrical or illuminated sign requires a licensed electrical contractor.
Swimming pool	See the open item on pools	Licensed swimming pool / spa contractor (CPC)	CPC licence. FS 489.103(6); FS 489.113(3)(c)	**OPEN ITEM.** Do not state this as settled. The department's materials have said FS 489.103(6) excludes in-ground pools from the owner-builder exemption. That subsection ends by stating it does not limit the exemptions provided in subsection (7), which is the owner-builder subsection. The effect of the two read together has been referred to the County Attorney. Until it comes back, tell the applicant a licensed pool contractor is the department's requirement and refer the question up - do not quote the statute as an automatic bar. Pool electrical bonding and wiring require a separate electrical permit either way.
Communication tower, or co-location on an existing tower	Licensed contractor or authorised applicant	Licensed contractor with PE-sealed structural plans	GC licence; PE structural seal. FS 489.113; FS 471; FCC rules	Tower fees and the required performance security are set by LDC 8.5 to 8.7, not by the Fee Schedule. The consultant escrow is refundable and must be topped up if drawn down.

III. What each permit covers, and what it does not

Use this to answer "is that included, or do I need a separate permit?" The rule running through all of it: the building or structure permit covers the structure, and the trades - electrical, plumbing, mechanical, gas - almost always need their own permits.

Permit	Covers	Does NOT cover
New construction (building permit)	The structural shell - foundation, framing, exterior walls, structural roof framing, and the roof covering. Roofing is included when installed as part of new construction.	Electrical, plumbing, HVAC/mechanical and gas - each needs its own trade permit.
Electrical	Wiring, panel and connections for the scope listed on the permit - new service, upgrade, outlets and switches, solar, or generator.	The structure itself. A generator also needs a separate gas permit if it is propane- or natural-gas-fed.
Renovations (plumbing / gas / mechanical / windows & siding)	The specific trade work listed.	Structural changes made to accommodate it, such as altering a load-bearing wall - that needs a building permit as well.
Mobile home set-up	Blocking, anchoring and the tie-down inspection only.	The electrical hookup, which needs a separate residential electrical permit, and the plumbing and septic connection, which is permitted by the Florida Department of Environmental Protection (DEP) - never the Health Department.
Roofing	Re-roofing and roof repair on an existing structure, priced by square footage.	Roofing on new construction - that is already in the new construction permit. Never charge a separate roofing fee for a brand-new building's roof.
Accessory buildings	The structure itself.	Any plumbing inside, which requires a DEP septic permit - not the Health Department - and any electrical, which needs a separate electrical permit.
Comprehensive plan review (site plan and similar)	Approval of the land use and site layout - setbacks, parking, drainage.	A building permit. Site plan approval does not substitute for the building permit required before construction begins.
Swimming pool	The pool structure and the required safety barrier.	Electrical bonding and wiring - a separate electrical permit, performed by a licensed contractor.
Decks and ramps	The structure itself.	Any electrical, such as outdoor lighting or outlets - separate electrical permit.
Porch / covered patio	The roofed structure attached to the dwelling, at a flat fee whatever its size.	Any electrical. Enclosing it as heated living space is charged at the residential per-square-foot rate, because it becomes living area.

IV. Intake: what to collect before accepting an application

Septic or sewer	Does the property have city sewer? If not, the applicant must provide a septic construction permit or an existing system approval from DEP before we accept the building application. A renovation that adds a bedroom to a home on septic also needs DEP approval, because it increases the system load. Note HB 589: a separate septic construction permit is not required where a building permit has been issued for the same single-family residence.
Notice of Commencement	Required once the total job value passes the threshold in the Fee Schedule notes. You can accept the application without it, but tell the customer the NOC must be recorded with the Clerk of Court and posted on the job site before the first inspection can be scheduled.
911 address	A 911 address must be confirmed or assigned before any inspection is scheduled on a new structure, and a Certificate of Occupancy cannot be issued without one on file.
Flood hazard status	Staff verify it. This governs whether the cosmetic-work exemption is available at all, and it is checked on the plot plan review for every project. A signed form from the applicant does not establish it.
Setbacks and the plot plan	Check the plot plan against the required yard dimensions for that land use category. The figures are in the Land Development Code, Schedule of Development Standards, Section 4.5 - read them from the Code. Note that the Schedule gives separate rows for building and for parking; use the building row for a structure. Confirm the parcel's land use category before reading the row.
River and creek buffers	A native vegetation buffer is required from the ordinary high-water line of the Apalachicola River, the Ochlockonee River, Telogia Creek and New River, and structures are not allowed inside it apart from boardwalks and piers. The buffer width and the exceptions are set by the Land Development Code - read them from the Code. This applies regardless of how small the structure is, so a shed too small to need a structural permit still needs the site checked.

Form lookup by situation

Situation	Form required
Any permit, every project	Application for Building Permit
Job value over the NOC threshold	Notice of Commencement, recorded before the first inspection
New construction or mobile home, no city sewer	Septic permit or existing system approval from DEP, before intake
No confirmed 911 address on file	911 Address Request
Owner acting as their own contractor	Owner-Builder Affidavit, signed in person
Property owner pulling site electrical only	Electrical Affidavit
Mobile home placement, new or used	Mobile Home Permit Worksheet (Blocking Plans)
Roofing permit using a third-party inspector	Roof Inspection Affidavit (3rd Party)

Situation	Form required
Barn, shed or garage with no plumbing planned	Pole Barn / Accessory Structure Affidavit
Sworn statement needed, no specialised form fits	General Affidavit
Cosmetic work exemption claim	Written Request for Exemption (HB 803)
Temporary hurricane or flood wall	Written Request for Exemption - pending standard confirmation

V. The forms

Application for Building Permit

When to use. Required for every permit type - this is always the first document collected.

What it does. Captures the owner, contractor, property description, valuation, zoning district, septic or sewer information and type of work. Staff assign the permit number, fee and surcharges on review.

Watch for. Under HB 803 the Florida Building Commission must develop a standardised statewide application by 1 July 2027, so expect this form to be replaced.

Notice of Commencement

When to use. Required once the total job value passes the threshold in the Fee Schedule notes.

What it does. Gives legal notice to lienholders that construction has begun, under Chapter 713, Florida Statutes. Identifies the owner, contractor, lender, surety and the expiration date.

Watch for. Must be recorded with the Clerk of Court AND physically posted at the job site. No first inspection is scheduled until staff confirm both.

Owner-Builder Affidavit

When to use. Required any time a property owner acts as their own general contractor, on new construction or on renovation work.

What it does. A twelve-point statutory disclosure under FS 489.103(7). The owner acknowledges the restrictions of the exemption, personal liability for all work and workers on site, that they cannot hire unlicensed persons to supervise, that they must occupy the property and may not sell or lease it within one year of completion, and that they accept full responsibility for code compliance.

Watch for. The owner must physically appear and sign - it cannot be mailed in or signed by a representative - and it must be notarised. A false declaration may be perjury, a third-degree felony. Does not cover solar wiring. See the open item on pools.

Electrical Affidavit

When to use. Required when a property owner pulls their own electrical permit for site power only - a power pole to a vacant lot, farm or future build site - and not for connection to any habitable structure.

What it does. The owner swears the service is for site power only and will not be connected to any residence, mobile home, camper or RV, and acknowledges that a separate permit and inspections are required before any such connection.

Watch for. Owner-specific. It does not apply when a licensed electrical contractor pulls the permit. If the customer later connects the service to a structure without a permit, the affidavit documents their declaration.

Pole Barn / Accessory Structure Affidavit

When to use. Required when a property owner builds any accessory structure and declares that no plumbing will be installed.

What it does. The owner swears the structure is for storage only, will not be used as living or camping quarters, and will contain no plumbing, toilet or water connection other than an outside spigot. Violation authorises the county to direct the power company to disconnect electric service until the ordinances are met.

Watch for. If the applicant mentions a sink, toilet or any interior water connection, do NOT have them sign it - they need a DEP septic permit first.

Roof Inspection Affidavit (3rd Party)

When to use. Required when a roofing permit uses a third-party inspector instead of the county inspector to verify roof deck nailing or a secondary water barrier. Submitted after the inspection. The third-party discount applies only when it is submitted.

What it does. A licensed inspector - engineer, architect, or an inspector certified under Chapter 468 - certifies under oath that they personally inspected the work and that it meets the Hurricane Mitigation Retrofit Manual per FS 553.844. Must be notarised.

Watch for. Photographs of each plane of the roof are required, with the permit number or address visible on the deck. A general contractor certified after 1973 without a roofing licence cannot perform or certify this inspection.

General Affidavit

When to use. A multipurpose notarised affidavit for a sworn statement that no specialised form covers.

What it does. The affiant swears before a notary that the facts declared are true to the best of their knowledge.

Watch for. This is a blank form. Staff must tell the applicant what they are attesting to before they sign. A false statement on it is a sworn false declaration.

Mobile Home Permit Worksheet (Blocking Plans)

When to use. Required for every mobile home set-up permit, new or used. The installer completes it before work begins.

What it does. Page 1 documents pier spacing, footer and pad sizes, marriage wall openings and tiedown components, with the installer sketching the blocking plan on the grid. Page 2 documents the penetrometer and torque probe soil tests, site preparation, multi-wide fastening, gaskets, weatherproofing, plumbing and electrical crossovers, signed and dated per Rule 15C-1 and 15C-2.

Watch for. All tests on page 2 must be performed by a licensed mobile home installer, not the property owner. A single-wide needs only half the blocking grid; triple and quad-wide homes need a full sketch.

911 Address Request

When to use. Required whenever a new 911 address is needed, or an existing one must be confirmed or corrected - new construction on a vacant lot, a mobile home placement, a power pole for a future build, or an accessory structure needing emergency access identification.

What it does. Captures the owner or applicant, contact details, parcel ID, location and directions, the type of request and the purpose of the address.

Watch for. Collect it before or alongside the building permit application for any new build or new site.

Written Request for Exemption (HB 803)

When to use. Required from the homeowner or contractor claiming the cosmetic-work exemption, before work begins.

What it does. The applicant initials each condition of the exemption and certifies the declared value. The office-use section records the flood hazard check and the determination.

Watch for. Staff verify flood hazard status - the signed form does not establish it. The same form is used for the temporary hurricane and flood wall exemption, which is still pending standard confirmation.

VI. Which review track: Type I or Type II

STEP ONE - ONE QUESTION

Ask one question: is the project a single-family home, a duplex, or an accessory structure to one of those? If yes, it is a Type I development and goes on the administrative track. If no - commercial, industrial, a subdivision or multifamily - it is a Type II development and goes to the Planning Board track.

The administrative track (Type I)

Applies to	New houses, barns, sheds, pools, decks and home additions.
Authority	LDC Section 3.02.01 (Type I review) and Section 4.6-3(A)(1).
What we collect	A building permit application and a development permit application.
The site plan	Section 4.6-3 exempts these from a formal engineered site plan. A plot plan - a basic sketch showing where the structure sits on the lot - is enough.
The review	The Development Administrator reviews the plot plan for the required yard dimensions and flood hazard status.
Approval	Staff sign off. Section 3.02.01 gives the Development Administrator authority to approve Type I projects without a board vote. No public notice, no ARPC memo, no board meeting.

The Planning Board track (Type II)

Applies to	Stores, gas stations, RV parks, subdivisions and special exceptions.
Authority	LDC Section 3.02.02 (Type II review) and Section 4.6-3.
The site plan	A formal plan meeting the requirements listed in Section 4.6-3(D) - drainage, parking, landscaping and the rest.
Technical referral	The county may send the project to the ARPC for a technical study. Section 4.6-3 gives the referral triggers, and any one of them is enough on its own - an acreage trigger, a dwelling or motel unit count, and a non-residential floor area. Read all three from the Code: a dense project on a small site is caught by the unit count even though it clears the acreage.
Public hearing	The project goes on the agenda for the Planning and Zoning Board, the County Commission, or both.
Board action	The board votes to approve, deny, or approve with conditions.

Gray areas - what pushes a project onto the full track

Change of use	Is a resident proposing to run a retail business out of a barn? That makes it commercial, and it moves to the Type II track.
Density	Does the number of dwelling units fit the parcel's land use category? The permitted density is in the Comprehensive Plan and the Land Development Code - read it from there and apply it to the parcel's acreage.
Special exception	Is the request for something the Code permits by special exception only, such as a communication tower? That requires a hearing.
Accessory or not	LDC Section 2.01 defines an accessory building as one incidental to the dominant use. A structure that will be lived in is not accessory - a pole barn house or barndominium is permitted as new residential construction.

Checklist

- Check LDC Section 2.01 - is the structure accessory?
- Check LDC Section 4.6-3 - is it exempt from site plan review? Single-family: yes.
- Check LDC Section 3.02.01 - approve via the Development Administrator.
- If any referral trigger in Section 4.6-3 is met, the project is Type II regardless of the above.

VII. Fee rules that are not amounts

The rules below govern how a fee is applied. Every figure they refer to is in the Fee Schedule.

Plan review	Included in the permit fee. There is no separate plan review charge.
Work started before the permit was issued	Carries a penalty multiplier on the permit fee - see the Fee Schedule.
Third-party inspection	A discount applies. See the open item below on how it interacts with the statutory private-provider minimums.
Private provider, s. 553.791	State law sets minimum fee reductions where a private provider performs plan review, inspection, or both. These are statutory minimums, not county discounts. The percentages are in the Fee Schedule notes.
Permit expiration and extension	A building permit expires one year from issuance. An extension is granted on written request to the department at no fee, and there is no renewal fee. See the open item on the single-family expiration rule.
Additional and re-inspections	The first re-inspection is not charged. Later ones, and any inspection beyond those included with the permit, are charged per trip and must be paid before the inspection is scheduled.
Fees set by the Land Development Code	Mobile home park plan review, final plat approval and communication tower fees are set by the Code, not by the Fee Schedule. Where the Code sets a fee, the Code controls.

Modification within the same category

When a structure has a permit on file that reached final inspection and closed out - even years ago - and it is now being modified into a higher tier within the same fee-schedule category, charge half the fee that would apply if the resulting structure were being permitted for the first time. Not half the difference between old and new: half of the new-build rate.

- Confirm there is a finaled permit on file for the existing structure. It does not need to be recent or open, just finaled at some point. No finaled permit means this rate does not apply - treat it as unpermitted work.
- Identify what the resulting structure would cost as a brand-new build, then charge half of that rate.
- Same-tier expansions are free. If a permitted structure is expanded but stays within the same size tier, there is no fee. The modification rate applies only when the change moves the structure into a higher tier.

A change of structure type

When a structure moves into a different major fee-schedule category entirely - not just a different tier of the same category, but for example an accessory structure converted to residential or commercial use - charge the full permit fee for the new category. No credit is given for what was paid on the original permit. The original permit covered the original structure; a change of use is reviewed and inspected as a new structure of the new type, so it pays that type's full fee.

ZONING COMES FIRST, ALWAYS

Zoning comes first, always. This calculation is irrelevant if the new use is not allowed on that property to begin with. An accessory structure becoming a dwelling or a commercial space is a change of use, which may require site plan review, a comprehensive plan check, or a conditional use hearing before the board. All of that has to clear first. Never quote a change-of-use fee before zoning has confirmed the new use is permitted at that location.

What counts as an accessory building

Accessory building covers any non-dwelling accessory structure whatever it is built from - pole barns, post-frame, metal or steel-frame barns, aluminium buildings, equipment sheds, carports, shops, workshops and lean-tos. The fee is set by whether the structure is open or enclosed, not by its construction method. A structure that will be lived in is not an accessory building: a pole barn house or barndominium is permitted as new residential construction at the residential rate.

VIII. Inspections

What follows is what the department's materials currently document. It is not a complete inspection sequence - see the gap note below.

Mobile home set-up	The block, anchor and tie-down inspection. This is the entirety of what the set-up permit covers.
Roofing, third-party path	Roof deck nailing and/or the secondary water barrier, verified by a licensed third-party inspector via the Roof Inspection Affidavit, with photographs of each plane of the roof showing the permit number or address.
New construction, first inspection	Cannot be scheduled until the Notice of Commencement has been recorded with the Clerk of Court and posted on the job site.
New construction, final inspection	Required before a Certificate of Occupancy is issued. A confirmed 911 address must also be on file.

KNOWN GAP - NO DOCUMENTED INSPECTION SEQUENCE

There is no documented step-by-step inspection sequence for a standard permit - the order and count of inspections a typical house requires (footing, slab, framing, rough-in for each trade, insulation, final), which trades trigger which inspections, and what must pass before the next stage proceeds. This does not appear in any of the department's written materials. It may live only with the Building Official. Until it is written down, do not tell an applicant how many inspections their project needs - ask the Building Official. Documenting the sequence is also a prerequisite for costing inspection fees accurately, since the fee should reflect how many trips each permit type genuinely requires.

IX. Counter scenarios

Worked examples of the questions that come up most often, and what to do with them.

An accessory dwelling unit for a relative

Situation. *A homeowner wants to place a pre-manufactured tiny home in their backyard for their aging parents.*

What to do. An accessory dwelling unit is a secondary, independent living space on the same lot as the main home. Charge the ADU fee plus Tier 1 site plan review to verify the yard dimensions. Even if the owner applies under the owner-builder exemption, FS 320.8249 requires a licensed mobile home installer to perform the physical setup. Electrical and plumbing hookups must be permitted separately by licensed trades.

A whole-home generator

Situation. *A customer is installing a backup generator.*

What to do. Two separate trade permits and two inspections. An electrical permit because it hardwires into the main panel, and a gas permit because it connects to propane or a natural gas line. It must pass an electrical safety inspection and a gas pressure and leak inspection.

Solar panels under the owner-builder exemption

Situation. *A homeowner wants to install solar panels on their roof themselves.*

What to do. Assess the solar permit fee. FS 489.103(7)(a)(3) is explicit that a licensed electrical contractor must perform all wiring and interconnection to the main panel. They cannot do the wiring themselves, owner-builder or not.

A used double-wide being moved onto a property

Situation. *A customer walks in to pull a permit to move a used double-wide onto their land.*

What to do. Charge the set-up permit plus Tier 1 site plan review. Tell them plainly what the set-up fee does not cover: it is the block, anchor and tie-down inspection only. They or their licensed trades must pull a separate residential electrical permit to hook the power pole to the home, and they must submit DEP septic approval before we let them fill out the application.

A barn that might get a sink and a toilet

Situation. *A resident wants an enclosed pole barn for farm equipment, and mentions they might put a utility sink and a toilet inside.*

What to do. Charge the enclosed accessory building fee. If they confirm no plumbing, have them sign the Pole Barn Affidavit. The moment they mention any water fixture, stop - they need a DEP septic permit before we proceed. This one question determines which path the application takes.

A package store near a school or church

Situation. *An applicant wants to open a craft beer package store in a commercial zone.*

What to do. This is a conditional use that goes before the board. There is a separation requirement from certain uses, but the distance and the list of protected uses are an OPEN ITEM - Ordinance 89-01 and LDC Section 4.3.1.1 give different figures and different categories, and the Code also imposes conditions the department's old materials left out. Do not quote a distance or tell the applicant they face automatic denial. Check the GIS map, note the distances to nearby schools and churches, and refer the question to the Building Official or the County Attorney.

A small shed on the riverbank

Situation. *A customer wants to put a small pre-poured plastic shed on the bank of the Apalachicola River, and says that because it is under the structural permit threshold they do not need the county's permission.*

What to do. Stop them. A native vegetation buffer is required from the ordinary high-water line of the Apalachicola and Ochlockonee Rivers, Telogia Creek and New River, and structures are not allowed inside it apart from boardwalks and piers. Read the width from the Land Development Code. Being too small to need a structural permit does not exempt a structure from the buffer - they need Tier 1 site plan review so planning can verify the site clears it.

A general contractor pulling a roofing permit

Situation. *A licensed general contractor comes in to pull a roofing permit for a client's standard home overlay.*

What to do. Check their DBPR licence date. Under FS 489.113, a general contractor certified after 1973 cannot pull a standalone roofing permit or self-perform roofing work unless they also hold a roofing contractor licence. If that is the case, do not take the intake - tell them a licensed roofing contractor must pull it.

X. Glossary

Commercial use	Any land use involving trade or retail with the general public, as opposed to manufacturing or wholesale distribution.
Single-family dwelling	A private residential building intended for one family unit, containing one kitchen and exactly one electrical meter.
Multifamily dwelling	A residential building designed for or occupied exclusively by three or more separate families. A duplex is a two-family dwelling, not multifamily.
Accessory building or use	A subordinate building or use - a detached garage, carport or tool shed - on the same lot as the main principal building. LDC Section 2.01 defines it as incidental to the dominant use.
Mobile home	A dwelling unit constructed entirely off-site and transported to the property, meeting HUD or ANSI standards according to its manufacture date. Under HB 803, local zoning may not treat it differently than site-built housing.
Recreational vehicle	A vehicle built on a single chassis, within the size limit set by the Land Development Code, designed strictly as temporary living quarters for camping, travel or seasonal use - never to be used or permitted as a permanent dwelling.
Setback	The minimum required horizontal distance a structure must be kept back from a property line or right-of-way. No building may encroach into it. The required distances are in the Land Development Code, Schedule of Development Standards.

Lot coverage	The percentage of a parcel physically covered by roofs, buildings or overhanging structures.
Site plan review	The administrative review where staff check a development's layout - parking, drainage, yard dimensions and buffers - against local regulations before a building permit is granted.
Variance	Dimensional relief from the zoning code, granted only by the Board of Adjustment where a physical hardship unique to the land makes literal compliance impossible.
Conditional use / special exception	A land use not permitted by right in a district because of its impact. It requires a public hearing and board-approved site conditions.
Private provider	A licensed engineer, architect or building code administrator authorised under FS 553.791 to perform plan review or inspection in place of the local building department.
Development Administrator	The staff position with authority under LDC Section 3.02.01 to approve Type I projects without a board vote.

XI. 2026 legislative changes and where each one stands

Every change below took effect in 2026. "Pending" means the department has not settled how to apply it, and staff should not answer from it without asking first.

Bill	Change	Status	What staff need to know
HB 803	Cosmetic work exemption for single-family homes	**Ready**	
HB 803	Temporary hurricane and flood wall exemption	**Pending**	The standard the wall must meet has not been identified. Do not waive a permit on this.
HB 803	One-year expiration for single-family permits	**Pending**	Sits alongside the department's existing rule that a permit is void if work does not start within six months, or is suspended for a year after it begins. Quote both timeframes until this is resolved; do not tell applicants the six-month clock no longer applies.
HB 803	Mandatory permit review deadlines	**Pending**	State law now sets response windows once an application is complete, graduated by project type and size. If the county does not issue timely written notice of incomplete items within the applicable window, the permit can be deemed approved by law and must be issued the next business day. The windows are in the statute. No tracking workflow exists yet - this is the most consequential open item on this page.
HB 803	Manufactured housing cannot be zoned differently than site-built	**Pending**	Do not deny or add conditions to a mobile home placement in a single-family district solely because the home is manufactured rather than site-built, if it otherwise meets the same standards. The zoning code has not yet been reviewed against this.
HB 803	Retaining wall spanning multiple parcels - one permit	**Ready**	Treat it as one application listing all affected parcels. Do not split it by lot.
HB 803	An HOA cannot require a permit before architectural review	**Ready**	Informational.

Bill	Change	Status	What staff need to know
HB 803	Narrowed local re-review of private provider work	**Pending**	An owner or contractor may use a private provider at any time, with no advance notice of inspection. Staff may generally review private-provider paperwork only for completeness, not substantive code compliance, except on local ordinance, floodplain and site-review matters. On a certified roof inspection, the Building Official may re-inspect only with specific knowledge the inspection was not performed, after written notice to the provider.
HB 803	Minimum commercial fee reductions for private providers	**Pending**	The department's third-party inspection discount is a single flat rate. The statute requires different minimums for plan-review-only, inspection-only and both. It has not been confirmed whether the flat rate was designed for commercial projects, residential, or both. If the county fails to apply at least the required reduction, it forfeits the ability to collect any fee for that project.
HB 803	Inspection fees may not be based on project valuation	**Pending**	Inspection fees must reflect the actual cost of providing the service, capped at the county's actual costs. The residential and commercial per-square-foot rates use floor area as a rough proxy for project value. Whether any part of those is legally an inspection fee is a fee-methodology question for the Board, not something to resolve at the counter.
HB 803	Statewide uniform permit application	**Future**	Due by 1 July 2027. No action yet.
HB 589	No separate septic permit where a building permit was issued	**Ready**	A separate septic construction permit is not required for a septic system where a building permit has been issued for the same single-family residence.
HB 927	Private professional plan review	**Pending**	Applicants may elect a county-preapproved private professional for plan review. The county charges no separate plan review fee either way; the applicant pays the private professional. The county keeps final approval authority. A review timeline applies, with automatic approval if the county does not act within the statutory window after a completion notice. The programme must be in place by 1 January 2027.

XII. Open items - do not answer these from this document

Each of these is unsettled. Give the applicant what is certain, say the rest is being confirmed, and refer it up.

Alcohol separation distance	Ordinance 89-01 and LDC Section 4.3.1.1 set different distances and different protected uses, and the Code imposes conditions the department's earlier materials omitted. Do not quote a distance. Refer to the Building Official or the County Attorney.
Owner-builder exemption and in-ground pools	FS 489.103(6) addresses pools, and ends by stating that it does not limit the exemptions provided in subsection (7) - the owner-builder subsection. The effect of the two read together has been referred to the County Attorney. State the department's requirement; do not quote the statute as an automatic bar.

Inspection sequence	No documented sequence exists for a standard permit. Do not tell an applicant how many inspections their project needs.
Hurricane and flood wall standard	The exemption applies only to a wall meeting specified standards, and the applicable standard has not been identified. Do not waive a permit.
Permit review deadlines	The statutory response windows are in force, but the county has no workflow for tracking them. A missed window can result in a permit being deemed approved by law.
Third-party discount versus statutory minimums	The flat discount rate has not been reconciled with the graduated statutory minimums for private providers.
Height limit for structures	The Land Development Code and the department's practice have been reported to differ. Read the limit from the Code and confirm with the Building Official before quoting one.

Questions on any specific project: Liberty County Building Department, (850) 643-2215. Legal and statutory questions go to Kenneth Hosford; anything else, a supervisor.